Divine Eyth

Carnegie Mellon University

Title: Eudaimonia, I Flourish In Contentment

I spent a large portion of my childhood between CMU's campus and the surrounding Oakland neighborhood. I could spend hours in the Carnegie Library, in the children's corner, across the sprawling fields of Schenley Park, past the food stands at the plaza, down Forbes Avenue, and through the manicured lawns leading up to Hunt Library.

Back then, I wasn't sure what I was going to do with my life, what I was going to make of myself. At one point I wanted to be a farmer, then an actress, then a writer. I could never quite decide, but I knew that whatever it was, I would be happy doing it.

As a self-proclaimed creative, I think often about what happiness means. It's such a simple word: happy. Two syllables. Five letters. My love-hate relationship with the English language—that popularized, rebellious love child of Latin—has everything to do with how simple the words are that we use to describe such huge emotions. Eudaimonia: the Greek word for the state of complete contentment and flourishing. ትዝታ: Tezeta, a feeling of nostalgia, and a genre of Ethiopian music often compared to the blues. I could go on. It would take me an eon to express what happiness means to me—what I mean when I say I wanted, and still want, to be happy.

But when I picture what happiness meant back then, before it took on too many names and faces (money, power, want), I see only one image: the first time I wandered alone through

Oakland, nowhere to be and everything to see. I walked farther than I ever had before on my own, past the Carnegie Library and into CMU's campus. The sun was out; maybe it was June. It was crowded with students. I was anxious, only for a moment, but when I stepped onto that lawn, when the light hit just right—the smell of fresh grass and pine needles and faint vanilla from my hand lotion—it felt as if everyone fell away. It was only me and the blue sky. I looked up at the towering architecture, wide-eyed (bushy-tailed!). There was a feeling in my chest—distinct, impossible to name—as if I would never want to be anywhere else.

There's an Alice Coltrane song I almost wrote an essay about during my freshman year of college: "Going Home." It evokes the same distinct yet impossible-to-name feeling. My crumpled drafts only ever had one word: Essence.

A name gives you power. A name defines you. James Baldwin writes, "I am what time, circumstance, history, have made of me, certainly, but I am also much more than that. So are we all." I was given the word Essence before I understood it—Divine Essence Eyth—before I had language for that warmth in my chest, before I realized that happiness might not mean a profession or a title but a feeling. A warmth I have only ever found in places that feel new and challenging and curious, places where thought is valued and knowledge is revered.

A place like Carnegie Mellon University, where, until now, I had only ever dreamed of studying. As a mixed woman, a child of two worlds, I often felt alienated for my intelligence yet unseen in spaces that didn't quite know where to place me. I kept my ambitions quiet, private; my secret. Even after staying out of school post-graduation and spending three years working full-time while my peers earned their degrees, I never stopped having a goal. I knew my path well; that quiet, overgrown, winding trail. Still, I feared I was being left behind. I feared I had made the wrong decision. I feared I had made a poor investment in myself.

Eudaimonia,

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I smell the candle burning in my new home, a home I found for myself. A place I worked for, climbed my own ladder for. It's Christmas. I stand beside my boss—a doctor, a CEO—as he introduces me to trusted colleagues. Clients. Friends. I am a friend. My coworker, a lawyer, laughs at a joke I make. A waiter refills my wine glass. I think about my résumé, its lack of diploma, for now. Yet I had earned my place at that table. I worked for my home. I am young, and I have built this. So I think: why shouldn't I apply?

"You don't get anything you want unless you ask for it." The best advice I ever received, from a man who really did get what he wanted. I took it seriously. I applied it. I applied. I am asking for what I want: this degree, this diploma, this school.

Happiness was going exactly where I wanted to be. Happiness is doing what I want because I know I want it, and because I know the only thing stopping me is asking. Baldwin reminds us, "The place in which I'll fit will not exist until I make it." This is me choosing to make mine.